



AI PM LAB

— by TRIGOSAT CONSULTING —

EXECUTIVE PRACTICAL GUIDE | JULY 2026 EDITION

Which AI Tool Should You Use for Each Task?

A task-first decision guide for writing, research, documents, data, images, coding, and automation.

Start with the work. Then choose the tool.

TASK FIT

What must the tool actually produce?

WORKFLOW FIT

Where does the information live and go next?

CONTROL FIT

What requires verification, privacy, and approval?



There is no single best AI tool.

The best choice depends on the task, the source information, the required output, the risk, and the software already used by the team.

Most AI buying decisions begin with product popularity. A stronger decision begins with the work itself.

- Use a general-purpose assistant when the task crosses writing, analysis, documents, images, or everyday problem-solving.
- Use a research-oriented tool when the answer depends on current web information, citations, and source review.
- Use a source-grounded workspace when the work should stay anchored to a controlled set of documents.
- Use an ecosystem copilot when the task should happen inside Word, Excel, Outlook, PowerPoint, Google Docs, Sheets, or Drive.
- Use a coding agent when work must happen across a repository, tests, terminal commands, and version control.
- Use an automation platform only after the process, trigger, inputs, review step, exceptions, and ownership are clear.

THE DECISION RULE

Choose the tool that reduces total work after review - not the tool that produces the fastest first draft.

This guide is task-first, vendor-neutral, and time-stamped because product capabilities, plans, and integrations change quickly.



Answer seven questions before comparing products.

These questions prevent feature lists from replacing real workflow analysis.

#	DECISION QUESTION	WHY IT MATTERS
1	What must the tool produce?	Text, research report, image, spreadsheet, slide deck, code, or automated workflow.
2	Where is the information?	In your notes, on the web, in PDFs, email, Drive, Microsoft 365, a repository, or a database.
3	How current must the information be?	Static reference material needs a different workflow from live market, legal, pricing, or news information.
4	What level of traceability is required?	Citations, source links, formulas, version history, approvals, and audit logs may be essential.
5	What is the risk level?	Creative brainstorming and high-impact financial, legal, staffing, or customer decisions should not use the same controls.
6	Where must the final output go?	The best tool may be the one already inside the destination application.
7	Is this one-time or recurring?	A recurring workflow may justify automation, templates, integrations, and monitoring.



Use the shortest path to a sensible shortlist.

The diagram below narrows the field before you test individual products.

QUESTION	IF YES	IF NO
Current web information required?	YES → Research-oriented assistant or deep research mode	NO → Continue
Controlled internal sources required?	YES → Source-grounded document workspace	NO → Continue
Work must happen inside Microsoft or Google apps?	YES → Ecosystem copilot	NO → Continue
Primary output is visual?	YES → Image/design platform	NO → Continue
Primary output is code in a repository?	YES → Coding agent or IDE copilot	NO → Continue
Task repeats across apps?	YES → Automation platform + human review	NO → General-purpose assistant

IMPORTANT

The shortlist is the beginning of the decision. Test each tool on the same real task before purchasing.



Start with the task category.

The tools listed are examples to evaluate - not permanent winners.

TASK	CAPABILITIES TO LOOK FOR	TOOLS TO EVALUATE
Writing & general work	Drafting, editing, reasoning, files, multimodal work	ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini
Current web research	Search, citations, source review, multi-step synthesis	ChatGPT Deep Research, Gemini Deep Research, Perplexity
Controlled document research	Answers grounded in selected PDFs, notes, and internal sources	NotebookLM, ChatGPT, Claude
Microsoft work	Word, Excel, Outlook, PowerPoint, Teams	Microsoft 365 Copilot
Google work	Docs, Sheets, Slides, Drive, Gmail	Gemini for Google Workspace
Images & visual concepts	Generation, editing, variants, brand production	ChatGPT Images, Adobe Firefly, Canva, Midjourney
Data & spreadsheets	CSV analysis, formulas, charts, in-sheet assistance	ChatGPT, Microsoft 365 Copilot, Gemini in Sheets
Coding & repositories	Planning, editing, testing, review, IDE or terminal workflows	Codex, Claude Code, GitHub Copilot, Gemini Code Assist
Automation	Triggers, integrations, branching, logs, exception handling	Zapier, Make, n8n, Power Automate

Availability and plan limits vary. Confirm the current product documentation before purchasing or designing a critical workflow.



Choose for context, revision quality, and workflow breadth.

A strong general-purpose assistant should support drafting, editing, structured thinking, files, and iterative refinement.

ChatGPT

Consider when: You want one broad workspace for writing, research, documents, images, data, and coding.

Strength: Wide task coverage and multi-format work.

Check: Plan-specific access, source verification, and data controls.

Claude

Consider when: You prioritize long-form writing, analysis, structured thinking, and careful document work.

Strength: Strong conversational drafting and analysis workflows.

Check: Integrations, plan limits, and the required final file format.

Gemini

Consider when: Your work already lives primarily in Google's ecosystem.

Strength: Natural alignment with Google apps and services.

Check: Workspace plan, admin settings, and feature availability.

TEST WITH ONE REAL TASK

Give each shortlisted tool the same notes, audience, output format, and review criteria. Measure total time after revision - not first-response speed.



Research tools should make verification easier - not optional.

Use them when the answer depends on current information, multiple sources, or a documented research process.

ChatGPT Deep Research

Consider when: You need multi-step research, source synthesis, files as context, and a documented report.

Strength: Broad research workflow inside a general-purpose work environment.

Check: Open the sources and confirm that each citation supports the claim.

Gemini Deep Research

Consider when: You need a research workflow connected to Google's ecosystem and web access.

Strength: Research planning and synthesis in a Google-centered environment.

Check: Source quality, plan access, and export requirements.

Perplexity

Consider when: You want fast web-oriented answers with visible source references.

Strength: Quick source discovery and conversational search.

Check: Do not treat cited summaries as verified evidence without opening the sources.

- Use primary sources for legal, financial, technical, product, and policy questions.
- Check publication date, jurisdiction, scope, and whether the source supports the exact sentence.
- Search for disagreement, not only confirmation.
- Separate retrieved facts from the model's interpretation and recommendation.



Choose based on source control and final deliverable.

Researching selected documents and producing a polished business output are related - but not identical - tasks.

SITUATION	TOOL TYPE	EXAMPLES
Ask questions across selected PDFs and notes	Source-grounded workspace	NotebookLM or a controlled project/workspace
Create a report from uploaded material	General assistant with document tools	ChatGPT or Claude
Work directly in Word, PowerPoint, Outlook, or Teams	Microsoft ecosystem copilot	Microsoft 365 Copilot
Work directly in Docs, Sheets, Slides, Drive, or Gmail	Google ecosystem copilot	Gemini for Google Workspace
Build a governed internal knowledge workflow	Permissions, source control, retention, review	Enterprise workspace + documented process

SOURCE-GROUNDED DOES NOT MEAN ERROR-FREE

The answer can still misinterpret a document, miss a qualification, or combine conflicting sources incorrectly. Review the cited passage.



The best tool may be the one already inside the work.

Integration can matter more than small differences in model style.

OPERATING ENVIRONMENT	NATURAL SHORTLIST	WHY
Microsoft-first team	Microsoft 365 Copilot + Power Automate	Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, Teams, business process automation
Google-first team	Gemini for Workspace + Google tools	Gmail, Docs, Sheets, Slides, Drive, collaboration
Mixed-tool small business	General assistant + one automation platform	Flexible drafting, files, research, and selected integrations
Document-heavy research team	Source-grounded workspace + general assistant	Controlled research plus polished deliverables
Software team	Coding agent + GitHub/IDE workflow	Repository understanding, review, tests, version control

Do not pay for a second AI platform merely to reproduce capabilities already included in the tools your team uses every day.



Separate visual exploration from controlled brand production.

A tool that generates impressive concepts may not be the best tool for repeatable branded assets.

ChatGPT Images Consider when: You want conversational image generation, visual exploration, and editing connected to broader work. Strength: Easy iteration from business context to visual direction. Check: Text accuracy, brand consistency, and final production quality.	Adobe Firefly Consider when: You need image generation and editing within an Adobe-centered creative workflow. Strength: Creative production, editing, and connection to Adobe tools. Check: Model choice, usage rights, plan credits, and final asset review.
Canva Consider when: You need fast social, presentation, and marketing assets using templates and brand controls. Strength: Accessible layout production and repeatable design workflows. Check: Avoid generic templates and verify every AI-generated claim or image element.	Midjourney Consider when: You prioritize visual ideation, art direction, and distinctive concept exploration. Strength: Strong visual style exploration. Check: Production workflow, text handling, editing needs, and brand repeatability.
PRACTICAL RULE Use generative tools to explore. Use controlled templates, human art direction, and review to publish.	



Choose between external analysis and in-sheet execution.

The right workflow depends on whether the data should leave the spreadsheet environment.

TASK	TOOL TYPE	CONTROL NOTE
Explore a CSV or spreadsheet	General assistant with file analysis	ChatGPT or comparable analysis workspace
Build formulas and work inside Excel	Microsoft 365 Copilot	Natural fit for Microsoft-centered teams
Work inside Google Sheets	Gemini in Google Workspace	Natural fit for Google-centered teams
Create recurring business reporting	Automation + database/dashboard	Do not rely on a manual chat workflow
High-impact financial analysis	AI support + independent calculation	Show formulas, assumptions, and source data

- Check row counts, signs, units, dates, duplicates, and missing values.
- Require formulas and calculation steps for every material number.
- Recalculate high-impact figures independently.
- Do not accept a polished chart that uses the wrong denominator or date range.



Choose based on where the deliverable must be finished.

Drafting content is different from producing a polished, editable, client-ready file.

NEED	TOOL TYPE	WHAT TO VERIFY
Draft narrative and structure	General-purpose assistant	ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini
Create/edit a PowerPoint in Microsoft workflow	Microsoft 365 Copilot	PowerPoint and Microsoft 365 context
Create/edit Google Slides	Gemini for Workspace	Google collaboration and Drive
Design a branded marketing deck	Canva or Adobe workflow	Templates, assets, and visual system
Generate a one-off executive artifact	Work assistant with document creation	Verify editability, export quality, and brand consistency

EXECUTIVE STANDARD

The final file should be editable, readable, consistent, and ready for the person who will actually use it - not only impressive in a preview.



Choose based on repository access, execution, and review.

A useful coding tool must fit the development workflow - not only produce code snippets.

Codex Consider when: You want an agent that can understand, plan, write, test, review, and ship code across a software workflow. Strength: End-to-end coding work connected to ChatGPT and repositories. Check: Review diffs, tests, branch behavior, secrets, and deployment effects.	Claude Code Consider when: You want terminal- and IDE-oriented coding assistance across an existing codebase. Strength: Repository-aware coding and agentic development workflows. Check: Tool permissions, commands executed, tests, and file scope.
GitHub Copilot Consider when: Your team works primarily in GitHub and supported IDE workflows. Strength: Coding assistance integrated with developer tools and GitHub. Check: Repository policies, review practices, and generated-code quality.	Gemini Code Assist Consider when: Your development environment and cloud workflow are Google-centered. Strength: Coding assistance for teams and cloud development. Check: IDE support, organization controls, and repository context.
DO NOT CHOOSE BY PREVIEW ALONE Choose based on whether you can inspect, test, version, reverse, and approve the changes.	



Automation begins with a controlled process.

A workflow needs more than an AI prompt.

Minimum design:

Trigger	Input	Rules	AI step	Human review	Output	Log	Exception handling
PLATFORM		TYPICAL STRENGTH			CONSIDER WHEN		
Zapier		Fast setup across many SaaS tools			Simple or moderate workflows, rapid experimentation		
Make		Visual multi-step orchestration			Complex branching and transparent scenario design		
n8n		Technical control and self-hosting options			Teams wanting flexibility, code, and infrastructure control		
Power Automate		Microsoft ecosystem integration			Organizations centered on Microsoft 365 and Power Platform		

FIRST AUTOMATION RULE

Automate a stable, understood process with a clear owner. Do not automate confusion.



Three broad work assistants to test first.

For many individuals and small teams, one general assistant is enough to begin.

TOOL	BROAD FIT	NATURAL USER
ChatGPT	Broad multi-format work: writing, research, documents, images, data, coding	Users wanting one flexible work environment
Claude	Long-form writing, analysis, documents, careful reasoning, coding	Users prioritizing text-heavy and analytical work
Gemini	General AI assistance connected to Google services	Google-first users and teams

- Select one as your default assistant for 30 days.
- Build repeatable prompts and review habits before adding subscriptions.
- Add a specialist tool only when a recurring task proves the need.



Match the research mode to the source boundary.

Current web research, source-grounded document research, and internal knowledge work require different controls.

RESEARCH NEED	NATURAL TOOL TYPE	CONTROL
Quick current answer	Web search + visible citations	Open the primary source
Complex multi-step report	Deep research workflow	Review plan, sources, dates, and scope
Selected internal documents	Source-grounded notebook/workspace	Verify quoted passages and conflicts
Research to client deliverable	Research tool + document creation tool	Separate evidence, interpretation, and recommendation

SOURCE RULE

A citation is useful only when it points to a real source that supports the claim you are making.



Use the smallest stack that covers the work.

The examples below are starting configurations, not mandatory bundles.

USER	STARTING STACK	GUARDRAIL
Solo professional	1 general assistant	Add image or research specialist only when recurring work requires it
Small business	General assistant + existing office ecosystem + 1 automation tool	Keep process ownership and review simple
Project coordinator / PM	General assistant + documents/spreadsheets + action tracking	Add automation only for stable recurring reporting
Real estate professional	General assistant + CRM/follow-up + controlled visual/document workflow	Avoid sensitive client data without authorization
Software team	Coding agent + GitHub/IDE + CI/test workflow	Require code review and protected deployment process



Score tools against real work.

Use the same task, input, and quality criteria for every product tested.

CRITERION	TOOL A	TOOL B	TOOL C
Quality for the real task	/5	/5	/5
Accuracy after review	/5	/5	/5
Document and file handling	/5	/5	/5
Sources and traceability	/5	/5	/5
Integration with current tools	/5	/5	/5
Privacy and admin controls	/5	/5	/5
Collaboration and handoff	/5	/5	/5
Automation potential	/5	/5	/5
Cost for required plan	/5	/5	/5
Time saved after revision	/5	/5	/5

Decision question: Does the tool reduce total work after review - or does it only produce output faster?



Run a seven-day practical test.

Do not compare tools with generic prompts or polished demos.

STEP	ACTION	WHY
1	Choose three recurring tasks	Use work you actually perform every week.
2	Prepare the same source inputs	Notes, documents, data, audience, and constraints.
3	Define acceptance criteria	Accuracy, completeness, editability, tone, and review effort.
4	Run each task in every shortlisted tool	Keep the instructions as consistent as possible.
5	Measure total time	Include correction, export, formatting, and handoff.
6	Review privacy and admin requirements	Especially before using client, employee, or confidential data.
7	Select one default tool	Add specialists only when the recurring workflow proves the need.



Tool selection is also a control decision.

The same task can be low risk with public information and high risk with client, employee, financial, or regulated data.

CONTROL AREA	QUESTION TO ANSWER
Data sensitivity	What data enters the tool? Is it authorized, minimized, and protected?
Plan and account type	Consumer, business, enterprise, and education plans may have different controls.
Retention and training settings	Confirm current product and organizational settings.
Access and permissions	Who can connect files, email, repositories, or business systems?
Human approval	Which outputs require a qualified or accountable reviewer?
Logging and audit	Can the team reconstruct what input, output, review, and decision occurred?
Vendor and model change	How will the workflow be revalidated when capabilities change?
MINIMUM STANDARD Do not connect confidential data, email, files, or repositories until you understand the account controls and have authority to do so.	



Define the task before opening a pricing page.

Task to improve	
Current process	
Required output	
Source information	
Current software ecosystem	
Traceability required	
Risk level	Low / Medium / High
Human reviewer	
One-time or recurring	
Shortlisted tools	
Test success criteria	
Final decision and reason	



This guide is intentionally time-stamped.

Capabilities, plans, names, integrations, and limits change. Re-check official product pages before purchasing or building a critical process.

Product references reviewed for the July 2026 edition:

OpenAI - ChatGPT overview: <https://chatgpt.com/overview/>

OpenAI - Deep Research: <https://openai.com/index/introducing-deep-research/>

OpenAI - Codex: <https://openai.com/codex/>

Anthropic - Claude: <https://claude.com/product/overview>

Anthropic - Claude Code: <https://claude.com/product/claude-code>

Google - Gemini for Workspace: <https://workspace.google.com/solutions/ai/>

Google - NotebookLM: <https://notebooklm.google/>

Microsoft - Microsoft 365 Copilot: <https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365-copilot>

Microsoft - Power Automate: <https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/power-platform/products/power-automate>

Adobe - Firefly: <https://www.adobe.com/products/firefly.html>

GitHub - Copilot: <https://github.com/features/copilot>

Google - Gemini Code Assist: <https://codeassist.google/products/business>

Zapier - AI automation: <https://zapier.com/ai>

Make - AI workflow automation: <https://www.make.com/en>

n8n - workflow automation: <https://n8n.io/>

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The right tool helps. A clear workflow creates the value.

Start with one real task. Define the input, output, review step, owner, and next action. Then choose the tool that fits the workflow - not the other way around.

EXPLORE MORE FREE RESOURCES OR REQUEST A MINI WORKFLOW REVIEW

<https://aipmlab.propertydex.xyz>

Use the free resources to improve one task. Use the workflow review to improve how that task is handled repeatedly.

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